CORNELL TECH | APPLIED MACHINE LEARNING

Human or AI?

Group 11: Project Report

Kaggle team: Group Number 11

Course GitHub PR: https://github.com/sekhari/human-or-ai-submissions/pull/13

Branch: `submission/group-number-11`

Submission status: Final selected model: DeBERTa-v3-small; public score confirmed

Final selection uses the best observed public AUROC, 0.92433. Public leaderboard reuse is part of model selection; private performance remains unknown.

Q0. Team information and model summary

Q0.1. Team members and main contributions.

Member	NetID	Contributions
Yilin Gao	yg695	Initial pipeline, model comparison and tuning (Q1); shared split and initial submissions.
Ansh Raj Bhargava	ab3396	Unlabeled-data experiments (Q3) and robustness improvements (Q5).
Yingzi Gu	yg667	Learning curves and error analysis (Q2/Q4); final refinement, reproducibility and LaTeX integration, with AI assistance disclosed in Q6.

Q0.2. Final pipeline, from text to probability.

The final model is DeBERTa-v3-small, initialized from pinned general-language pretrained weights and fine-tuned using only competition labels. We normalize whitespace, retain the first 256 tokens, freeze embeddings, and train the encoder and classifier for two epochs. The development run uses the fixed 8,000/2,000 split; a separate final model is trained from the original pretrained weights on all 10,000 labeled rows. Softmax supplies uncalibrated AI scores. No pseudo-labels or ensemble are used in the selected submission. The neural-method appendix specifies settings and provenance.

Q0.3. Final scores.

Metric	Score
Selected model validation AUROC	0.989423
Selected model Kaggle public AUROC	0.92433
Selected model Kaggle private AUROC	Not yet available

Selected file: `submission_deberta.csv`. The rank blend scored 0.92164; the later robustness continuation scored 0.91085. We retain both negative comparisons. Public scores guide final selection and are not an untouched estimate of generalization.

All development runs use the committed 8,000/2,000 split. Most use seed 42; the robustness continuation uses 2026. No raw or case/whitespace-normalized exact cross-split duplicates were found; near duplicates were not exhaustively tested.

Q1. Model comparison and selection

Q1.1. Preprocessing and text representation.

We use light preprocessing to preserve stylistic cues. The word vectorizer lowercases text and uses scikit-learn's default word-token pattern (tokens of at least two word characters), with unigrams and bigrams. Character features use lowercased character 3–5-grams and retain local punctuation and spacing patterns. Both vectorizers use minimum document frequency 2, sublinear term frequency, their default smoothed IDF and L2 normalization, with caps of 100,000 word and 150,000 character features. Each vocabulary and its IDF weights are learned exclusively from training data. Character features complement vocabulary with morphology and local formatting. The historical classical refinement adds supervised NB feature weighting, defined in Q5; it does not apply the Unicode folding tested in the robustness experiment.

Q1.2. Comparison of three modeling approaches on the same split.

Model (word TF-IDF)	Train AUC	Val. AUC	Fit (s)
Linear SVM ($C = 1$)	1.000000	0.943355	2.16
Logistic regression ($C = 1$)	0.995359	0.934601	2.14
Complement NB ($\alpha = 1$)	0.984366	0.896508	1.91

Current-environment rerun. All three use word TF-IDF; timing includes feature extraction and classifier fitting, excluding evaluation. Historical teammate results are retained separately and differ slightly because the original environment was not pinned.

Q1.3. Hyperparameters for at least two approaches and selection protocol.

For logistic regression we searched $C \in \{0.1, 0.5, 1, 2, 5\}$; for the linear SVM, $C \in \{0.01, 0.1, 0.5, 1, 2\}$. All other settings and validation IDs were fixed. The best word-only values were $C = 5$ and $C = 0.5$, respectively. We selected by held-out AUROC without test labels. Full results are below; this is model selection on a reused holdout rather than an unbiased final test estimate.

Model	C	Train AUC	Val. AUC
Logistic Regression	0.1	0.959492	0.908819
Logistic Regression	0.5	0.986518	0.928824
Logistic Regression	1	0.995359	0.934601
Logistic Regression	2	0.999386	0.939157
Logistic Regression	5	0.999999	0.942735
Linear SVM	0.01	0.956640	0.905830
Linear SVM	0.1	0.995047	0.935096
Linear SVM	0.5	1.000000	0.943666
Linear SVM	1	1.000000	0.943355
Linear SVM	2	1.000000	0.942228

Q1.4. Final selection and subsequent changes.

The word/character SVM reached 0.971228 validation AUROC. NB weighting then reached 0.977012, and the NB/style blend reached 0.988136; their public scores were 0.85994 and 0.88628. Contextual DeBERTa reached 0.989423 locally and 0.92433 publicly. Its rank blend improved local AUROC to 0.994594 but reduced public AUROC to 0.92164. The later robust neural candidate scored 0.91085 publicly. We therefore select the original pure DeBERTa using observed public results. This is adaptive selection, not an independent test. Q2 holds the classical configuration fixed for a controlled size experiment; Q3 preserves the unlabeled-data study; Q4 below evaluates the selected neural model. Q5 and the appendices retain all improvement stages and failures.

Q2. Effect of training data size

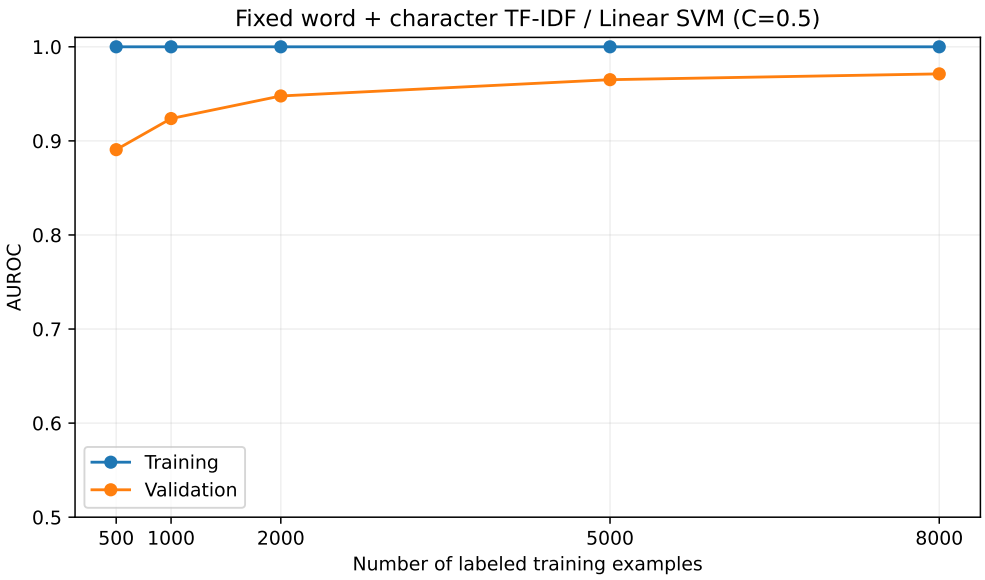
Q2.1. One fixed configuration at five training sizes.

We use the original word + character TF-IDF / SVM ($C = 0.5$) configuration throughout this experiment. This is the supervised reference configuration, not the final neural model. Using seed 42, we independently shuffle each class pool and interleave them to obtain balanced, nested training subsets. The 8,000-row fit retains the original committed row order. Every size refits its own vocabulary and IDF weights, with identical hyperparameters and the same untouched validation IDs.

Training rows	Train AUC	Val. AUC	Fit (s)
500	1.000000	0.890672	0.63
1,000	1.000000	0.923734	1.28
2,000	1.000000	0.947738	2.62
5,000	1.000000	0.965055	6.26
8,000	1.000000	0.971228	9.77

Times include TF-IDF and SVM fitting, excluding scoring and probability calibration. Subset membership is recorded in `learning_curve_subset_ids.csv`.

Q2.2. Learning curve.



Q2.3. Overfitting, underfitting and the value of more labels.

Training AUROC is 1.0 at every size, while validation AUROC increases monotonically from 0.890672 to 0.971228. The initial gap of 0.109328 is consistent with overfitting in a high-dimensional representation, not an inability to fit the training observations. The gap falls to 0.028772 at 8,000 rows. There are diminishing returns: adding 3,000 examples from 2,000 to 5,000 improves validation AUROC by 0.017317; adding another 3,000 improves it by 0.006173. More labels from a similar distribution therefore appear useful, but this single seeded curve does not establish uncertainty or the gain beyond 8,000 examples. Additional in-distribution data may also fail to address unseen domains or adversarial editing.

Q3. Learning from unlabeled data

Q3.1. Method and leakage prevention.

Person B tested confidence-based self-training using the 3,000 unlabeled passages. The supervised word + character SVM predicts margins, transformed to probabilities with a logistic sigmoid fitted to five-fold out-of-fold training margins. Passages with estimated AI probability at least t or at most $1 - t$ receive pseudo-labels and are added to training. Thresholds $t \in \{0.99, 0.95, 0.90, 0.80, 0.50\}$ were compared, followed by up to three rounds at the best threshold. Vectorizer fitting, calibration, and pseudo-label generation exclude the fixed validation set. Validation labels select settings but do not train models. These exploratory calibration folds share a vocabulary fitted on the 8,000-row training partition; the revised NB-stage implementation instead refits the full pipeline per fold.

Q3.2. Supervised versus unlabeled-data results.

Method	Pseudo rows	Val. AUC	Time (s)
Supervised baseline	0	0.971122	64.85
Fit TF-IDF on training + unlabeled	0	0.971217	89.17
One round; confidence 0.99	1118	0.971113	75.49
One round; confidence 0.95	1849	0.971640	75.44
One round; confidence 0.9	2167	0.972072	75.65
One round; confidence 0.8	2479	0.972052	75.14
One round; confidence 0.5	3000	0.971796	75.32
self-training round 1; confidence 0.9	2167	0.972072	75.10
self-training round 2; confidence 0.9	2239	0.972232	87.93
self-training round 3; confidence 0.9	2255	0.972122	100.66

Person B's committed Kaggle-environment results, preserved without replacing them with another environment's numbers. Runtime includes feature preparation; later self-training rounds report cumulative runtime. The current-environment reference AUROC is 0.971228 versus historical 0.971122.

Q3.3. Did it help, and what limits the conclusion?

Self-training helped modestly: the best recorded two-round result was 0.972232 versus 0.971122 for supervised learning, a gain of 0.001110. At threshold 0.90, the first round added 2,167 pseudo-labeled passages; the second added 2,239. Lower thresholds admit more data but can introduce noise. In a training-only simulation, threshold 0.90 selected 2,022 of 3,000 held-back labeled examples with 1.88% error, compared with 9.6% when all were selected. This is an optimistic in-distribution diagnostic, not the error rate on genuinely unlabeled data. Threshold and round selection reuse the validation set, so the small gain is not independent confirmatory evidence.

Connection to the historical NB refinement

We also evaluated a reproducible two-round candidate with threshold 0.90 and a frozen sigmoid fitted from three-fold, full-pipeline out-of-fold training scores. Freezing avoids recalibrating on folds that contain pseudo-labels generated using all training targets. This revised procedure obtained 0.972186, above the current supervised baseline but below NB weighting. It differs from Person B's procedure and is reported as a separate experiment, not an exact reproduction. Its pseudo-label counts were 2,171 and 2,254. The final selected model therefore remains supervised.

Q4. Generalization and error analysis: final DeBERTa

Q4.1. Training versus validation

Training AUROC is 0.995930; fixed-validation AUROC is 0.989423, a gap of 0.006507. The gap is consistent with some overfitting; repeated selection also limits the estimate. Public AUROC falls to 0.92433, showing a larger distribution/generalization gap. These diagnostics use the development checkpoint, not the all-label final fit.

Q4.2. Text-length subgroups

The same training-derived word-count boundaries (175 and 240 words) define short, medium and long validation groups. AUROC evaluates ranking; the neural classifier's default logit-zero rule corresponds to an uncalibrated softmax value of 0.5.

Length group	Count	Neural AUROC	Submitted blend
Long	646	0.991526	0.991192
Medium	643	0.987055	0.987089
Short	711	0.990983	0.986215

At the default threshold, the neural model produces 204 false positives and 18 false negatives (88.9% accuracy). Its high AUROC does not imply a good operating threshold or calibrated probabilities. No validation-optimized threshold is presented as an unbiased test result.

Q4.3. Five false positives and five false negatives

FP denotes human text predicted AI; FN denotes AI text predicted human. These are five confident errors of each type, not a representative sample. Reasons are inspection-based hypotheses, not proven causes or label corrections.

ID	Type	Softmax AI	Possible reason from inspected passage
3326	FP	0.999685	Fluent, conventional review structure resembles generated exposition; surface polish is an ambiguous authorship cue.
8238	FP	0.999608	Regular academic framing and repeated technical categories may resemble generated abstracts. The first 256 tokens omit later detail.
1761	FP	0.999542	Formulaic research-summary language resembles AI academic prose despite concrete method details.
3364	FP	0.999512	Structured instructional prose and repeated terms may be mistaken for generated explanations.
1585	FP	0.999412	Predictable abstract structure may dominate the decision; input truncation can hide later quantitative details.
2209	FN	0.008062	Recipe conventions are shared by both classes; ingredient-heavy opening text supplies weak authorship evidence.
7018	FN	0.010987	Technical surface detail resembles a human abstract; authorship classification does not verify the scientific claims.
7837	FN	0.013223	Colloquial imperfections and first-person review style resemble human user comments.
424	FN	0.016915	Recipe vocabulary and informal wording resemble human recipes, while truncation removes much of the later sequence.
7995	FN	0.018833	Reference-style detail and irregular presentation resemble human source text; the model does not verify biographical accuracy.

Q4.4. Failure patterns and targeted response

Human abstracts and structured explanations cause confident FP; recipes, informal reviews and biographies cause FN. Shared genres obscure authorship. A controlled 256-versus-384-token comparison with other settings fixed could test whether later context helps. The robustness continuation changes several factors and cannot isolate that hypothesis. Separate domains and calibration need further evaluation.

Q5. Open-ended improvements and insights

Q5.1. Hypotheses motivating improvements.

Person B hypothesized that Unicode folding and typo augmentation could reduce brittleness to edited AI text, as the assignment describes adversarially modified test passages. Word/character TF-IDF matches local forms, so visually similar characters or inserted invisible characters may change features. In a later refinement, we hypothesized that class-informed feature weighting could emphasize discriminative word and character patterns instead of treating TF-IDF dimensions equally before regularization. These are separate experiments: robustness is evaluated on both original and synthetically perturbed validation passages, whereas the classical refinement stage used the original fixed validation set; the eventual neural selection also used public results. Neither hypothesis guarantees improvement on the hidden test distribution.

Q5.2. Changes and controlled comparisons.

For robustness, R0 is word-only SVM; R1 is the word + character baseline; R2 adds NFKC normalization, selected homoglyph folding, zero-width removal and whitespace normalization; R3 additionally augments both training classes with typos. All retain SVM $C = 0.5$ and the fixed split. The stress tests perturb only AI-labeled validation passages using typos, Cyrillic look-alikes, or inserted zero-width characters; they are synthetic conditions, not known test-set memberships.

For refinement, we specified six candidates: baseline, character weight 2, character-only features, logistic regression $C = 5$, NB weighting, and revised two-round self-training. With binary training-document occurrence counts n_{cj} for class c and feature j, NB weighting adapts Wang and Manning (2012) to TF-IDF:

$$p_{cj} = \frac{1 + n_{cj}}{\sum_k (1 + n_{ck})}, \qquad r_j = \log \frac{p_{1j}}{p_{0j}}, \qquad x'_j = x_j r_j.$$

The same word/character TF-IDF settings and SVM $C = 0.5$ are retained. Counts use training labels only and are refitted within calibration folds. Validation labels never define r_j.

Q5.3. Measured results.

Configuration	Original	Typos	Homoglyph	Zero-width	Fit (s)
R0	0.9433	0.9404	0.9027	0.9185	5.12
R1	0.9711	0.9696	0.9578	0.9600	28.53
R2	0.9597	0.9576	0.9597	0.9597	28.94
R3	0.9590	0.9573	0.9590	0.9590	53.96

Historical Person B run. All score columns are validation AUROC; original means unmodified validation. Runtime includes feature extraction and fitting.

Candidate	Train AUC	Val. AUC	Fit (s)
Original word + character SVM	1.000000	0.971228	9.80
Character block weighted 2x	1.000000	0.971349	9.78
Character-only SVM	0.999978	0.969718	8.27
Word + character logistic regression	1.000000	0.969331	12.05
NB-weighted word + character SVM	0.999964	0.977012	10.39
Self-training, two rounds (revised)	1.000000	0.972186	41.14

Current-environment refinement. Time includes fitting and, for self-training, its internal calibration; final output-probability calibration is separate. Test data were not accessed by the candidate-selection script.

Q5.4. Support for the hypotheses, limitations and next steps.

Unicode normalization reduced original-validation AUROC from 0.971122 to 0.959700, and typo augmentation did not recover it (0.959011). Homoglyph robustness improved slightly, but the reported paired interval included zero. We therefore did not adopt normalization merely because it seemed intuitively robust. NB weighting improved original-validation AUROC from 0.971228 to 0.977012. A paired 1,000-resample bootstrap gives a descriptive 95% interval of [0.001478,0.010103] for its AUROC gain. This interval is conditional on the selected candidate and is not adjusted for repeated model selection. Thus the result supports further testing but does not prove improvement on unseen generators or adversarial text. All six candidates and negative results remain recorded. The submitted pipeline scored 0.85994 publicly versus 0.85049 for the earlier word-only submission; this is not an isolated test of NB weighting. Private performance remains unknown.

Q6. Code, reproducibility and AI assistance

Q6.1. PR, entrypoints, dependencies and final predictions.

PR: https://github.com/sekhari/human-or-ai-submissions/pull/13

Run from `submissions/group-number-11/`, with supplied data in `data/competition/`. The recorded neural run uses Python 3.14.2, pinned dependencies, seed 42 and local Apple MPS bfloat16.

```
python -m pip install -r requirements-neural.txt
python download_pretrained.py
python train_neural.py --data_dir data/competition --mode validate --epochs 2 --batch_size 16 --accumulation 2 --
    max_length 256 --learning_rate 0.00003 --precision bf16 --freeze_embeddings
python evaluate_neural.py
python diagnose_neural.py --data_dir data/competition
python train_neural.py --data_dir data/competition --mode refit
python verify_neural_results.py --data_dir data/competition
python export_selected_submission.py
```

The selected prediction file is `artifacts/submission_deberta.csv`; the export command copies its verified bytes to `artifacts/final_submission/submission.csv`. The repository README maps every question to commands and results. Checkpoint and input hashes distinguish development from full-data training. Raw data, passages, caches and weights stay excluded from Git. The standalone Overleaf ZIP includes all LaTeX sources and figures. The final public score is 0.92433; private score is not yet available. Classical Q2/Q3 experiments retain their original configurations and are not presented as neural learning curves or neural self-training results.

Q6.2. Development history and lessons.

- 8b44412 (Q3/Q5): self-training helped slightly; normalization could hurt original-validation performance.
- c8e5c1f (Q2/Q4): more labels narrowed the gap; error inspection exposed ambiguous genre cues.
- e999954 (final refinement) adds NB weighting, six-candidate comparison and updated Q4; the following commits integrate LaTeX. All candidates and selection limitations are retained.

Q6.3. AI assistance and verification.

Codex assisted Yingzi Gu with code, execution, debugging, passage inspection, hypotheses and LaTeX drafting. Automated checks validate split membership, metrics, calibration, IDs and submission hashes; the rendered PDF was visually checked. These are not claims of human review. Each member should review the report, understand the approach and confirm their own tool disclosure before submission. Results are measured, failure explanations are hypotheses, and unknown Kaggle scores remain unfilled. No external LLM API predicted test labels and no hidden labels were retrieved.

Post-submission audit and improved submission

Status. This appendix preserves the historical NB stage (public AUROC 0.85994); the final main report selects DeBERTa. This appendix records a subsequent independent review and the NB/style blend. The blend has confirmed public AUROC 0.88628; private AUROC remains unknown.

What the review found

The high fixed-validation score did not establish generalization. Among the supplied labels, no human passage contains double newlines, while 3,301 of 5,000 AI passages do. Many large NB coefficients involve line breaks or template markers. Applying Unicode/quote/whitespace normalization to both validation classes reduces NB AUROC from 0.977012 to 0.917921; also removing punctuation gives 0.888169. These tests demonstrate sensitivity, not the exact cause of hidden-test errors.

An independent three-fold classifier distinguishing training text from test text achieves AUROC 0.730335, confirming observable distribution differences without test labels. Submission IDs and ranks were verified; the increasing sigmoid preserves AUROC. No exact cross-split text duplicates were found. Removing three validation examples with training-neighbor similarity at least 0.9 leaves AUROC 0.976943, insufficient to explain the public-score gap.

Independent generalization diagnostics

Using only the official 8,000 training texts, unigram TF-IDF, 48-dimensional SVD and K-means form 12 label-free text clusters. Three-fold GroupKFold holds complete clusters out. These are inferred text groups, not known hidden domains. An ordinary stratified three-fold control uses a similar training size. Neither diagnostic changes the official 2,000-row validation IDs.

Model	Fixed val.	Random CV	Cluster CV
Submitted NB model	0.977012	0.969897	0.903318
Style-only model	0.958415	0.955965	0.895069
75:25 NB/style blend	0.988136	0.984046	0.945723

CV values are unweighted means of three fold AUROCs. These are exploratory diagnostics; grouped folds differ in size and composition.

New model and evidence limits

The content-light style model uses normalized text, function-word proportions, lexical diversity, word/sentence-length distributions, punctuation/character statistics and sentence repetition. It is a histogram gradient-boosting classifier (220 iterations, learning rate 0.06, 15 leaves, minimum leaf size 30, L2 penalty 10). Each component margin is divided by its own training-score standard deviation; the selected blend uses 75% NB and 25% style. We compared four components and three fixed blends. Among candidates retaining the old fixed-validation AUROC, this blend has the best mean cluster-CV AUROC and improves every cluster fold. Selection is exploratory and reuses validation results; it is not preregistered confirmation.

The blend reaches fixed-validation AUROC 0.988136, with 26 false positives and 72 false negatives at margin zero. Its normalized-text stress AUROC is 0.964515; residual sensitivity remains. It is refitted on all 10,000 supplied labels, with full-pipeline three-fold calibration and no external labels. The separate file is `artifacts/submission_robust_blend.csv`. See `PROJECT_REVIEW.md` for findings and reproduction commands. The public score remains far below fixed-validation AUROC; improved validation alone does not resolve the distribution gap.

Final DeBERTa model: method and measured results

Status. The pure neural model scored 0.92433 publicly; the fixed neural/NB-style rank blend scored 0.92164. Both improved on the earlier NB/style blend (0.88628), but the locally better rank blend was worse publicly. Private scores remain unknown.

Hypothesis and experimental protocol

After observing the validation/public gap, we tested whether contextual pretrained representations could complement local n-grams and stylistic statistics. We used Microsoft's general-purpose DeBERTa-v3-small, following DeBERTaV3 (He et al.). The exact weight revision is recorded in `neural_results/pretrained_source.json`. Pretraining is external general-language training; the only supervised labels in our fine-tuning are the supplied competition labels. All training and prediction run locally, with no external inference API or hidden labels.

Training uses the same 8,000 training IDs and evaluates the same 2,000 validation IDs. We normalize whitespace, truncate to 256 tokens, freeze pretrained embeddings, and fine-tune the encoder and new classification head. Settings: AdamW, learning rate 3×10^{-5}, weight decay 0.01, batch 16, accumulation 2, 10% linear warmup followed by linear decay, gradient clipping at 1, seed 42, bfloat16 on Apple MPS, two epochs. We retain the better validation checkpoint. Validation labels select the epoch but never enter gradient updates. Test labels are unavailable.

Measured local results

epoch 1: 0.987573; epoch 2: 0.989423. Selected epoch: 2. Validation-run time (including evaluation and checkpointing): 21.2 minutes.

Model	Fixed-validation AUROC
submitted_robust_blend	0.988136
deberta	0.989423
deberta_robust_rank50	0.994594

We also test one fixed 50:50 mean-percentile-rank blend of the neural scores and the previously submitted NB/style scores; there is no weight sweep. Ranks are computed separately within validation and test predictions without labels. These ensemble outputs are ranking scores, not calibrated probabilities. Checkpoint and candidate selection reuse the holdout; all comparisons are exploratory.

Selected-checkpoint training AUROC is 0.995930; validation AUROC is 0.989423. Normalizing Unicode, quotation marks and whitespace in both classes gives 0.989299; also removing punctuation gives 0.980220. These are synthetic stress tests, not measured hidden-test conditions.

Limitations and submission procedure

About 50.5% of validation texts exceed 256 tokens, so truncation discards potentially useful evidence. A 384-token limit would truncate 8.4%, but the later combined robustness experiment changes several factors and does not isolate context length. Neural softmax outputs are uncalibrated. Epoch selection and repeated reuse of validation may inflate apparent gains. The observed public scores remain below validation scores, showing that the distribution gap persists.

The final neural candidate is retrained from the pinned pretrained weights on all 10,000 supplied labeled rows using the chosen epoch count and training settings. Its file is `artifacts/submission_deberta.csv`; the fixed ensemble is `artifacts/submission_deberta_robust_rank50.csv`. Prediction hashes and input hashes are recorded separately, so earlier leaderboard scores cannot transfer to new predictions. See `NEURAL_EXPERIMENT.md` for reproduction and limitations. Full-data refit and test inference took 30.3 minutes. The later robustness continuation scored 0.91085 and was rejected; the original pure model remains the final selection.

Final robustness continuation

The pure neural model scored 0.92433 publicly versus 0.92164 for its rank blend, reversing validation ordering. With one submission opportunity and one hour of local compute, we tested robustness continuation. It scored 0.91085 publicly, below the original neural model by 0.01348; it was rejected for final selection.

Changes and leakage control

Validation starts from the saved 8,000-row model; final fitting starts from the separate model already trained on all 10,000 labels. Checkpoint and input hashes are recorded. The full-data model is never evaluated on overlapping validation labels. No external labels or prediction API are used. A microbatch-32 attempt was discarded. The final continuation uses 320 microbatches (5,120 augmented rows; 0.512 of a full-data epoch), retaining the nominal 500-microbatch learning-rate schedule. The starting model already trained on all 10,000 labels. Development validation used 500 microbatches, so its scores do not measure these deadline-limited final weights.

The validation model receives one additional epoch with a 384-token window, with random contiguous crops for overlength training passages. At inference, overlength passages average 384-token head and tail logits. Unicode, selected homoglyphs, quotation marks and whitespace are normalized. Training perturbations are label-independent: 50% normalized clean, 30% with 4%-word typos, 10% with random punctuation removal, and 10% lowercase. Settings include AdamW LR 8×10^{-6}, effective batch 32, label smoothing 0.05, frozen embeddings, seed 2026 and local MPS bfloat16; full settings are in the reproduction guide.

Diagnostic comparison and adaptive window check

Clean evaluation retains all 2,000 official validation IDs. Three synthetic conditions use the same balanced 1,000-row subset (seed 2026), altering only AI passages to simulate evasion. Their unmodified reference AUROC is 0.989270. Actual hidden attack types and prevalence are unknown. Training augmentation affects both labels; production preprocessing never uses labels.

Model	Clean	AI typos	AI no punct.	AI lowercase
Original neural	0.989423	0.958672	0.954470	0.957322
Equal mean, 384-token views	0.989344	0.969364	0.962426	0.971642
Equal mean, 256-token views	0.988736	0.967640	0.961680	0.969764
Robust continuation	0.983753	0.976120	0.967872	0.981568
Robust, 256-token views	0.981190	0.972120	0.966440	0.978730

After the 384-token candidate lost clean AUROC, we additionally checked 256-token head/tail views on the same conditions. This window check was adaptive, not preregistered. The original rule used a clean AUROC floor of 0.985 and favored the equal neural mixture. After observing that the robust-only model wins all three stress conditions and the overall mean, we explicitly relaxed the floor to 0.98 and selected it. This trade-off revision is adaptive, not preregistered; the original rule and all results remain recorded. The condition mean is a selection heuristic, not predicted Kaggle AUROC. All candidates are neural.

Selected: Robust continuation. Clean validation AUROC: 0.983753; four-condition mean: 0.977328. Validation training and diagnostics took 23.7 minutes. Final refit and inference took 15.6 minutes.

Reproduction and limitations

See `FINAL_REFINEMENT.md` and `run_last_refinement.py` (validate/refit modes). The separate output is `artifacts/submission_final_robust_neural.csv`. The verifier checks metrics, selection, IDs, transforms and hashes. Sigmoid outputs are uncalibrated.

The reused holdout and synthetic tests do not establish hidden-domain performance. Context, normalization and augmentation form a combined intervention, not isolated effects. The observed public decline shows that these synthetic gains did not transfer. The changed preprocessing, augmentation, context window and shorter final continuation are confounded; no single failure cause is established. Private scores remain unknown.